



IBM's Watson computer system, powered by IBM POWER7, competed against Jeopardy's two most successful and celebrated contestants – Ken Jennings and Brad Rutter

learning and statistical techniques with the latest in natural language processing to result in human-like precision and speed, huge breadth and accurate confidence determination.

“The challenge is to build a system that, unlike systems before it, can rival the human mind’s ability to determine precise answers to natural language questions and to compute accurate confidences in the answers,” said Dr. David Ferrucci, leader of the IBM Watson project team. “This confidence processing ability is key. It greatly distinguishes the IBM approach from conventional search, and is critical to implementing useful business applications of Question Answering.”

“Progress on the underlying QA technologies enabling Watson will be important in the quest to understand and build ‘intelligent computing systems’ capable of cooperating with humans in language-related tasks previously out of reach for computers,” added Dr. Ferrucci.

Creating a level-playing field

In the pure amount of information stored in its memory, Watson can’t be beaten by any human. As stated before, the challenge with Watson isn’t being able to come up with a question on Jeopardy. The challenge lies in understanding the natural language being spoken by the quizzer and coming up with a solution where the system is confident enough – and doing it all at a speed in which it can press the buzzer.